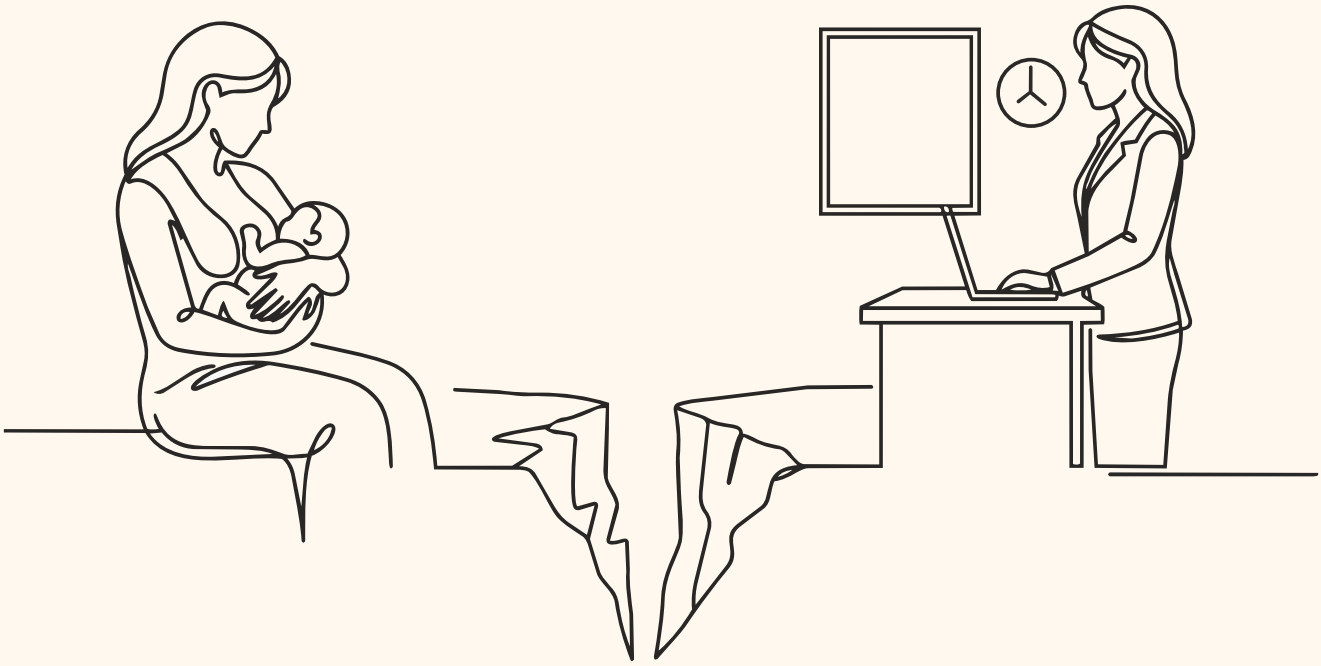
A MOM BOSS WELLNESS RESEARCH WHITE PAPER



The Return Gap

What happens to mothers in the first quarter back at work

You are not broken. The system did not adjust.

ORIGINAL SURVEY AND INTERVIEW RESEARCH
SUMMER 2026

MOM BOSS wellness

AUTHOR'S NOTE

I had every advantage. I still came apart.

I've just gone back to work after my third parental leave in seven years. All three returns have had one thing in common: the woman walking back through the door is never the woman who left. This time the distance is the widest it's been. In four months I became a mother again, kept caregiving for my own mother, and turned into a family of five, all at once. My mom was there for so much of my first leave. Since then she's been diagnosed with dementia and moved into memory care, and that has been its own long, hard road.

My first leave should have been the easy one. My employer gave me six months paid, which puts me in a tiny minority of American mothers, and my leader backed me the whole way. I had every structural advantage the current system can offer, and I still came apart on the way back, because nobody had made a plan for the person walking back through the door. I'd been someone driven by her career. Now I was also someone's mother, and nothing in my working life had a place to put that. It was the biggest identity shift of my life, and I tried to carry it alone. I know now how many mothers go through it quietly. Those are the women I hope this work reaches.

> Six months of paid leave was the easy part. Nobody had a plan for the woman coming back through the door.

My next two leaves shook things up in other ways. During the second, my husband was laid off as he came back from his own parental leave. He was out of the building during a restructure and couldn't advocate for himself. He became a stay-at-home dad, and the shape of our family changed because of a decision made inside somebody else's org chart. This time he's running his own creative company, and I'm holding a newborn and a mother in memory care at the same time.

Three leaves, one woman, three completely different sets of conditions. My readiness wasn't what changed. The workplace I walked back into changed, and almost none of that was mine to control. I've spent my career in data, so I did what I know how to do. I built a survey, started interviewing women, and went looking for the places where the numbers and the stories line up.

Prefer to listen? I recorded a short audio overview of the findings for the drive to daycare or the quiet after bedtime. **Listen to the audio overview**.

Every woman quoted here spoke to me on the condition of confidentiality. They are identified by role and location only, and every word is theirs.

THE OVERALL PICTURE

Six findings from over 100 mothers

88%
DREADED RETURNING TO WORK

17%
WERE GIVEN A PLAN FOR IT

20%
LEFT THE JOB THEY CAME BACK TO

One finding sits underneath all the others: 12 women volunteered a layoff or a job threat around their leave, in a survey that never asked about layoffs.

Paid leave is essential, and it is not the whole answer. The United States is the only developed country with no mandated paid leave, and that must change. Yet among the women here who did receive leave, its length predicted almost none of the 21 outcomes I measured, including anxiety about returning and whether they eventually quit.

1. **The crisis lives in the return, not the leave.** 88% dreaded going back, 70% considered leaving within six months of returning, and 20% left the job they came back to.
2. **Almost nobody plans the return.** Only 17% had any structured conversation with their manager about coming back, the lowest score in the survey, and the gap it leaves is one an employer can close in an afternoon.
3. **The load compounds while the support falls away.** Each additional child raises the conflict between a woman's professional and maternal identity, and lowers the odds that anyone at work prepares for her return.
4. **Other mothers are infrastructure, not a nice-to-have.** Women connected to mothers who understood them were less likely to feel they had to prove themselves all over again at work.
5. **Women are not mainly asking for more time off.** A structured, phased return was named as often as a longer leave, and the loudest request of all was for someone at work to plan, cover and advocate for them.
6. **Length of leave is not what moves these numbers.** Across four leave-length bands, anxiety, proving yourself again and considering leaving barely move, and none of the differences clear sampling noise.

WHO THIS RESEARCH SPEAKS FOR

Over 100 mothers, and the ones this paper misses

More than 100 women have completed the survey since August 2026, recruited through LinkedIn and my email list, and responses are still arriving. That channel shaped the sample in a specific direction, and being precise about it makes the findings harder to dismiss rather than easier.

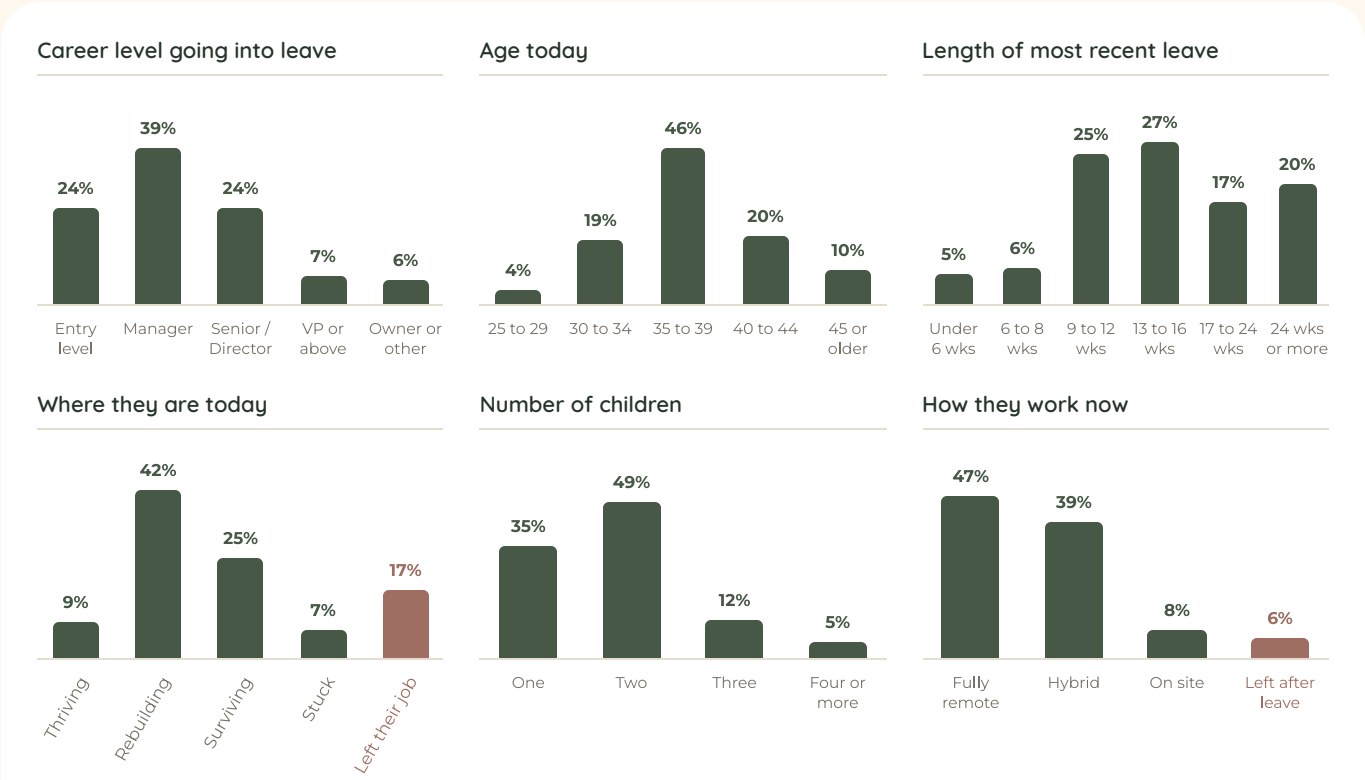


Figure 1. The first 109 women who answered, across six dimensions. Every panel is the same 109 respondents broken out a different way, so shares are of all respondents rather than of the currently employed. Gold marks women not yet back; rose marks the women who left. Percentages are rounded. The survey remains open.

These are high-achieving, professionally established women, most of them knowledge workers with laptops and some control over their own calendars. The paper therefore does not speak for hourly workers, shift workers, women in retail or care work, or the vast majority of mothers around the world, whose experiences are almost certainly harder. The survey sample is predominantly United States based; the interviews span the United Kingdom, South Africa and multiple US locations.

> *"The pitiful leave I had, is still considered good by many."*
>
> OPERATIONS DIRECTOR, HEALTHCARE, CHICAGO

This is the most structurally advantaged group of mothers the American workplace produces, and 88% of them still dreaded going back. If the system fails these women at this rate, it is not a story about individual resilience.

The gap at the center of everything

The survey tells you the shape of the problem and the interviews tell you how it happens. Wherever the two meet, the same thing is true: what breaks women is not the leave, it is the return.

88% of the women I surveyed were anxious about going back to work. Only 17% had any structured conversation with their manager about that return, which is the lowest score of all 21 statements I measured. Put those two together and the picture is stark: almost nine in ten women walked back into work carrying real dread, and fewer than two in ten were given anything resembling a plan. That is not a wellbeing problem with an operational cause. It is an operational failure with a wellbeing symptom.

88% dreaded going back. 17% were given a plan.

The single widest gap in the survey. Anxiety about returning was near universal. A structured conversation with a manager before the first day back was the lowest scoring item of all 21 measured.

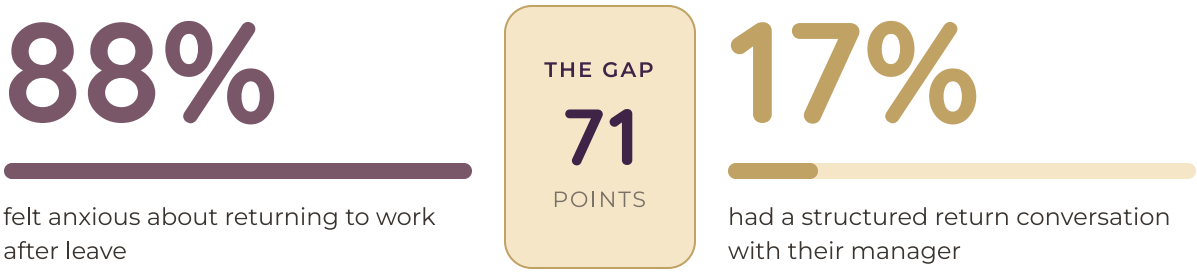


Figure 2. The widest gap in the survey. Share agreeing (4 or 5 on a 5-point scale). Anxious about returning, n = 109. Manager held a structured return conversation, n = 108. The 71-point gap compares two separate items. It isn't a change over time.

The consequences follow directly from that gap. Seven in ten respondents considered leaving, and one in five left the job they came back to within six months of returning. Every one of those departures was preceded by a return that nobody planned.

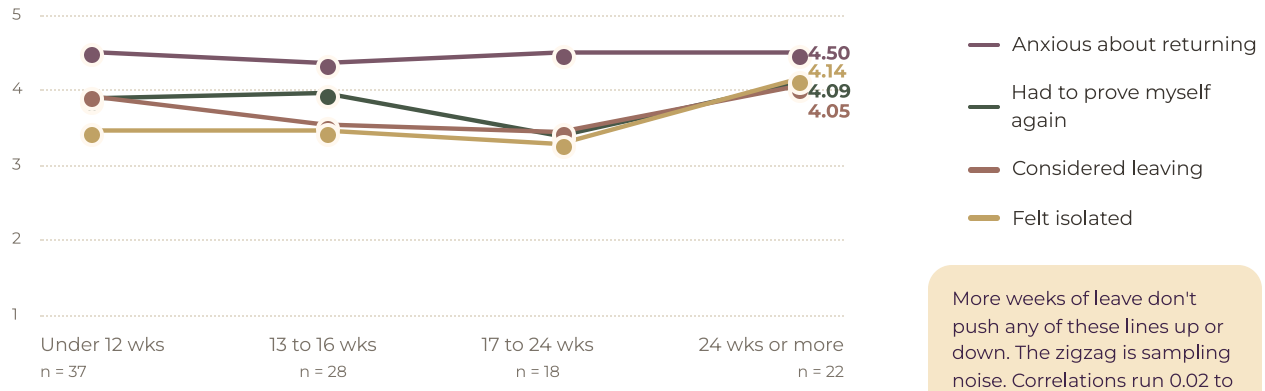
Paid leave is essential. On its own it is not enough.

Let me be plain about where I stand. Of 41 developed countries, the United States is the only one that does not mandate paid parental leave, and the minimum among the other forty is roughly two months. That is a policy failure, and my recommendations start there.

Leave alone does not help with the outcomes once a mother re-enters the workplace. There are structural flaws in our system that fails moms returning, no matter the length of leave. Among the women who did receive leave, I tested how long they were away against all 21 outcomes, and length predicted almost none of them: not anxiety about returning, not having to prove themselves again, not damage to their advancement.

More weeks alone did not change the return

Four outcomes tracked across four leave lengths, on the same 1 to 5 scale. If length of leave mattered, these lines would climb or fall together. Instead they move sideways.



More weeks of leave don't push any of these lines up or down. The zigzag is sampling noise. Correlations run 0.02 to 0.16, and none are significant.

The interviews say the same from both ends of the spectrum. The UK offers up to 52 weeks and South Africa offers 12, and the women I spoke to in both described the same collapse on re-entry. A technology sales leader in California took 26 weeks and found the length itself became part of the problem, with isolation amplified by postpartum depression and a readiness to return well before her leave was over. Many of the mothers cited isloation as a core issue while on leave and not having "adult" conversations. They also missed their professional identity and speaking with many of their work colleagues while on leave. With that said, most survey respondents were anxious about return with no plan in place no matter the length of leave.

Fund the leave. Then build the return.
More weeks in front of a broken re-entry is a longer runway to the same cliff.

Nobody plans the return

All 21 survey items. The plum bars are what she carried in herself, and they dominate the top of the chart: anxiety about the return at 88%, sleep deprivation at 86%, pressure to get back to normal quickly at 80%. Those three arrive together, and the combination is the flaw. A depleted woman is asked to perform as though nothing happened, and the anxiety follows. The gold bars are the short list an employer directly controls.

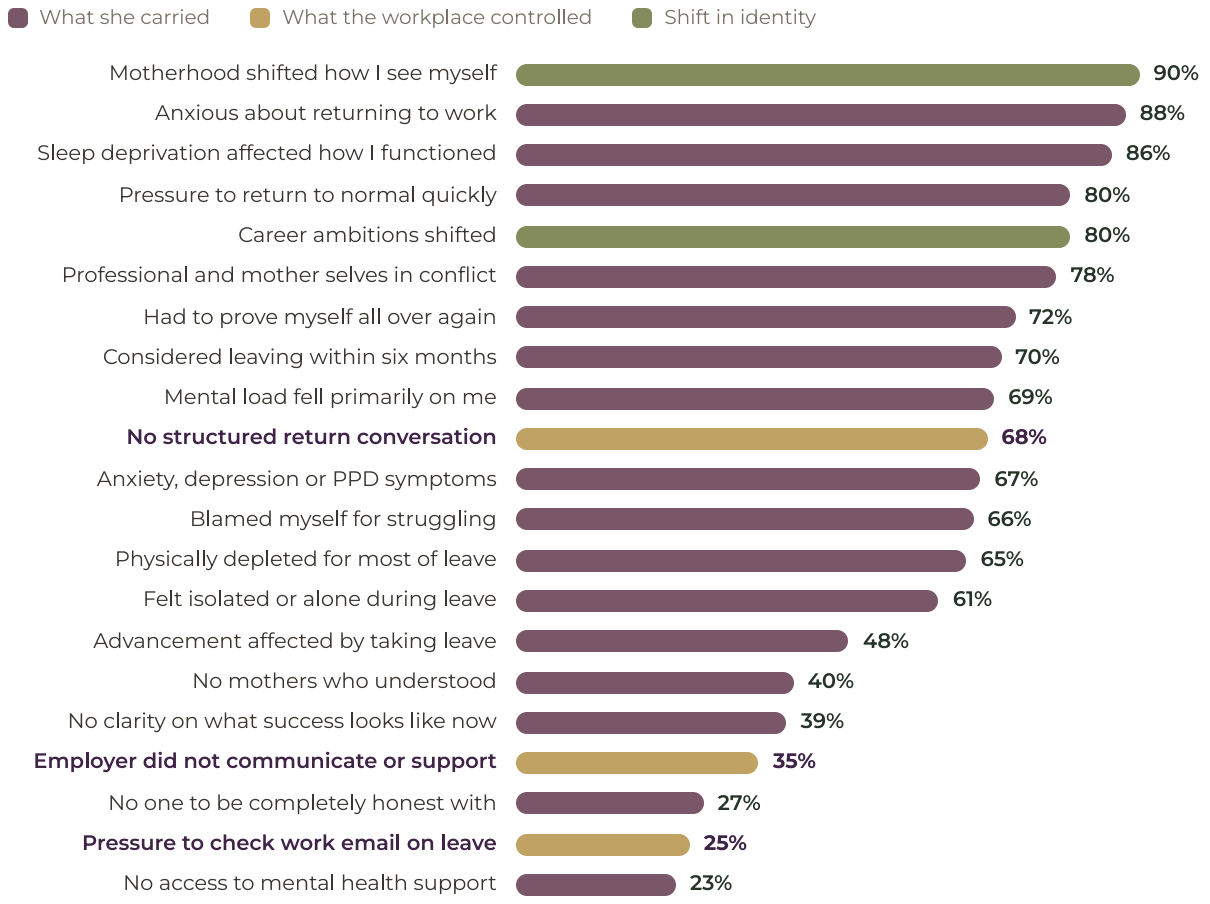


Figure 4. All 21 statements, reverse coded so a longer bar always means more harm. Share giving the harmful answer, meaning agreement of 4 or 5 on negatively worded items and disagreement of 1 or 2 on positively worded ones. n = 109, one item n = 108. Two items describe change rather than damage and are marked in sage.

Companies can shift the re-entry to assist a mom coming back into the workforce after a leave no matter the length. This will help immensely what she's carrying during and after her leave as well as the identify shift. When managers have a plan and structured conversations, better outcomes will unfold for both the company and individual mom.

What "no plan" looks like, and why the manager decides

A cybersecurity professional in Missouri, fully remote with what she called total flexibility, came back to nothing at all.

> *"There's all the flexibility, but there's zero conversations about anything [related to re-entry]. It was just like, okay, you're back. Here's your stuff."*
>
> CYBERSECURITY PROFESSIONAL, MISSOURI

An account leader at a US technology company was handed something worse. She had gone out eight weeks early on doctor's orders, and the first document she received on her return was a mid-year review covering the months she had been absent. It was among the worst of her career, and she was marked down because a direct report had struggled while she was away.

> *"I wanted a forward-looking conversation, not a backward-looking review."*
>
> ACCOUNT LEADER, US TECHNOLOGY COMPANY

An energy technology lead in Texas came back from six months of paid leave only to find out that the project she had been leading was quietly shelved while she was out.

> *"No one seems to care that I'm back."*
>
> ENERGY TECHNOLOGY LEAD, TEXAS

Only a quarter of women felt any pressure to check work email during leave, so the problem was never that work intruded on their time away. Instead, work went silent, and then expected her to go from a standing start to full speed. Even though a planned return did not settle the nerves before day one, it did change what happened after. Women whose manager prepared a return process were measurably less likely to feel like they had to prove themselves all over again. The cleanest evidence is a natural experiment inside one company, where a remote team leader in Dallas took two separate leaves under the same company policy, but under two different managers, and experienced two entirely different environments.

SAME COMPANY, FIRST LEAVE

A manager who prepared for her return

- Leave was normalized early on
- Coverage was arranged for her
- Explicit no-contact expectations were set before she left
- She describes the return as blissful in hindsight

SAME COMPANY, SECOND LEAVE

A manager who did not

- "Are you going to go dark, or work a little during leave?"
- The coverage plan was handed to her to solve while pregnant
- She expects the second return to be far harder

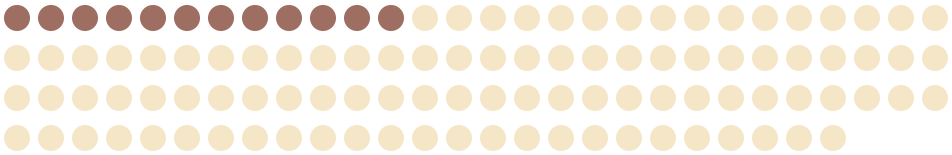
Policy is what an organization writes down. The manager is what a mom returning from leave actually experiences, and almost nobody trains for that.

The pattern nobody names

My survey never asked about layoffs. Twelve women brought them up anyway: laid off at seven months pregnant, one week before a return date, on a first day back. One watched her employer lay off a different mother who was still on leave.

Nobody asked them about layoffs

Each circle is one of the 109 women who took the survey. Twelve raised a layoff or a job threat on their own, in their own words.



12 volunteered a layoff or job threat 97 did not mention it

Figure 5. Found by keyword search across the leave-type field and both open responses, then checked by reading each response. No question asked about layoffs, so treat twelve as a floor. It isn't an estimate of how common this is. n = 109.

A startup operator in Seattle took four months of paid leave and extended it by a month because she was struggling. She was laid off as a result. Back on the job market, she called the leave a sabbatical, because she believed being honest would make her unhireable.

> *"It feels like a dirty little secret in corporate America and in tech that we just don't talk about."*
>
> STARTUP OPERATOR, SEATTLE

Contractors are exposed in a different way. An organizational development consultant in Kentucky worked as a contractor through her first pregnancy, with no paid leave and no protections.

> *"I had to save 30% of my take-home pay away to cover for my own leave. "*
>
> ORGANIZATIONAL DEVELOPMENT CONSULTANT, KENTUCKY

The fear starts before the leave does. An energy technology lead in Texas waited until she was almost four months pregnant to tell her manager, so the news would land before a layoff list was drawn up and hopefully her employer's compassion would keep her on payroll. The same consultant, now pregnant with her second and job searching, was advised to disclose nothing until she had an offer in hand. Keeping that information back didn't sit well with her.

When women watch colleagues get cut around their leave or not hired, the rational move is to keep the pregnancy quiet or delay the news.

The load compounds. The support does not.

This is the strongest demographic pattern in the data, and I rarely hear anyone talk about it. With each additional child, the conflict between a woman's professional identity and her identity as a mother goes up. Meanwhile, the chance that anyone at work planned her return keeps dropping.

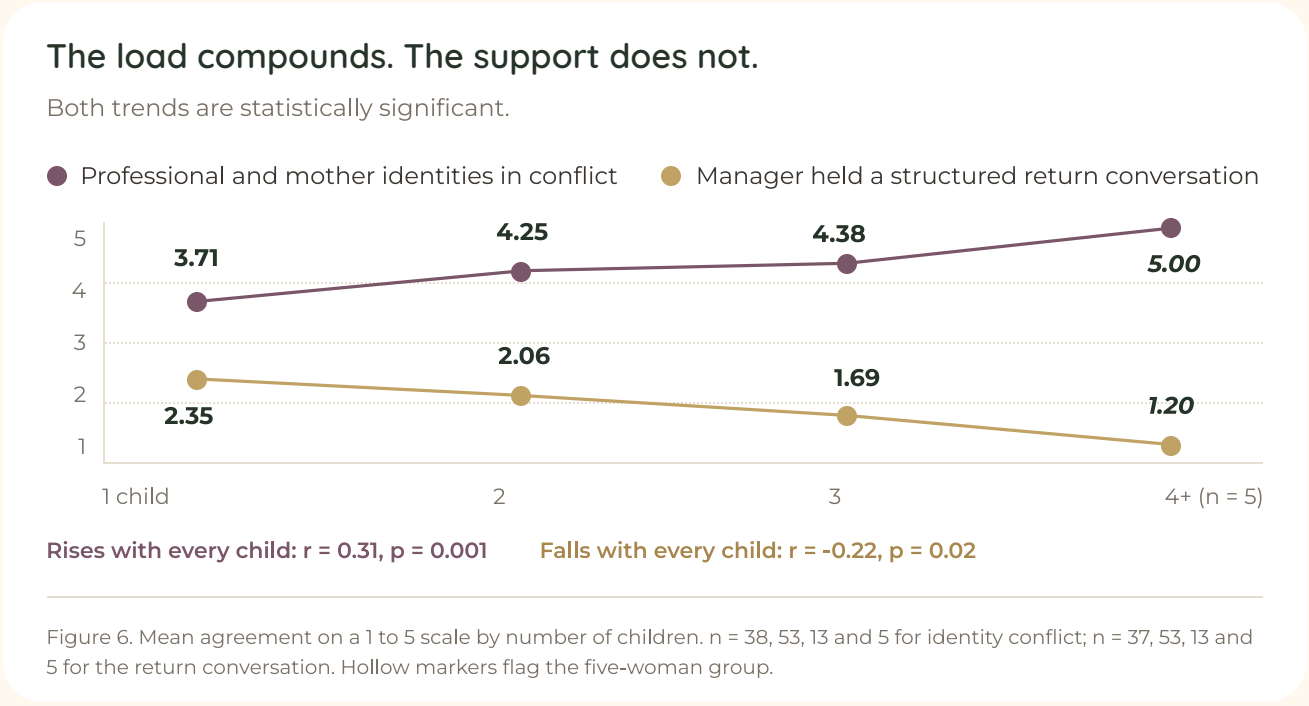


Figure 6. Mean agreement on a 1 to 5 scale by number of children. n = 38, 53, 13 and 5 for identity conflict; n = 37, 53, 13 and 5 for the return conversation. Hollow markers flag the five-woman group.

Employers treat the second and third leave as routine at exactly the moment a woman's total load has doubled. The remote team lead in Dallas came back after having twins, one of whom spent four and a half weeks in the NICU. She put the assumption into words.

> *"I feel like people are kind of like, oh, you figured it out by now. Every kid and time back is different."*
>
> REMOTE TEAM LEAD, DALLAS

Each return is a different woman walking into different conditions, with a different household behind her. A sourcing analyst in Minnesota took 13 unpaid weeks for her first child, and her husband took almost none. For her second, she had 16 weeks of state paid leave, and he took three weeks up front and two more when she went back to work. That handoff made her return much easier. The lesson she drew from it is worth keeping: the default-parent pattern gets set during leave, and even with an involved partner, it's hard to undo later.

> *"The biggest thing I'd love to see a study on partners leave and then how does everyone feel about the parenting workload a year later, two years later?"*
>
> SOURCING ANALYST, MINNESOTA

The village is lost, bought, or never found

Loneliness was the second most common answer when I asked what was hardest about leave. Only 41% of women connected with other mothers who understood what they were going through. That connection pays off at work, too. Women who had it were significantly less likely to feel they had to prove themselves again, and significantly less isolated. It's the only variable in this dataset that moves a career outcome and a wellbeing outcome at once.

> *"Our villages are often created through our employment or education. It means that when we take parental leave we have effectively lost that support."*
>
> SURVEY RESPONDENT

For most professional women, community gets built at work, and leave pulls her out of it right when she needs it most. Women who can afford it buy the village outright: a night nurse, a postpartum doula, more hours of childcare. Once a working support system is something you have to purchase, caregiving quietly becomes a class issue.

Identity is the through line

90%

SAY MOTHERHOOD SHIFTED HOW THEY SEE THEMSELVES

78%

FELT THEIR PROFESSIONAL AND MOTHER SELVES IN CONFLICT

37%

FEEL CLEAR ON WHAT SUCCESS LOOKS LIKE NOW

That last number is the one I keep coming back to. Close to two thirds of these women don't have a definition of success they actually believe in right now. That's a different problem from being tired or disorganized. Everything around them, including the performance systems they're measured by, still assumes the person who existed before the child arrived. An operations director in Chicago described the expectation plainly: you've been through a massive identity shift, and you're expected to deal with it on your own time.

> *"We are expected to work like we don't parent, and society is pushing us to parent like we don't work."*
>
> ACCOUNT LEADER, US TECHNOLOGY COMPANY

What they actually asked for

At the end of the survey, I asked what support women wished they'd had and didn't get, from anyone at all. Ninety-five women answered in their own words.

What women asked for, in their own words

Coded from 95 open-ended responses. The top five themes are within a few points of each other, which at this sample size means they're effectively tied.

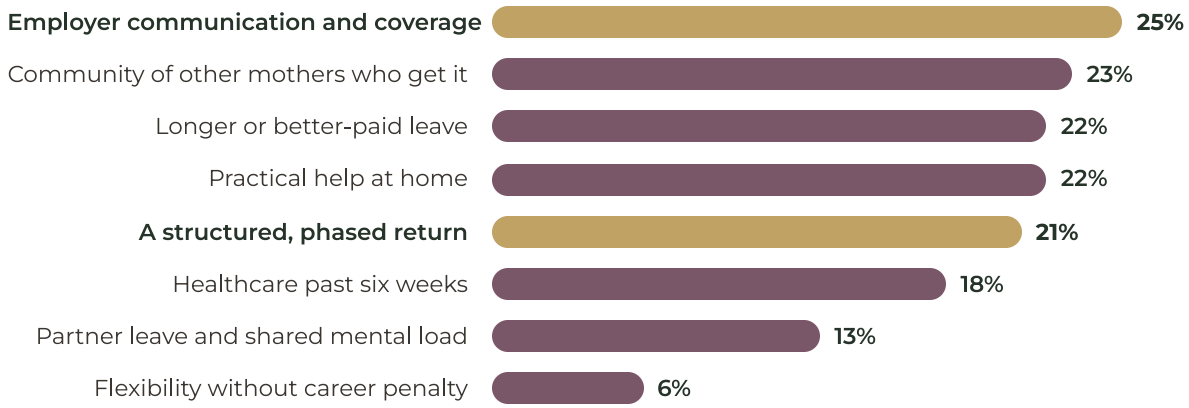


Figure 7. Share of the 95 respondents naming each theme. Responses could name more than one theme, so shares don't add to 100. With n = 95, the margin on each share is roughly 8 points, so the top five can't be ranked against one another. Read them as one cluster.

Two of those top five sit with the employer, and they overlap: communication and coverage at 25%, and a structured, phased return at 21%. Together they describe someone at work who planned for her return, covered her work and advocated for her. A community of other mothers who get it sits in the same cluster at 23%. No policy can issue that, and every workplace can help build it. Longer or better-paid leave matters at 22%, it shares the top of the list with everything else.

**Women aren't only asking for more time away.
They're asking for a return someone actually planned.**

Three levels. One redesign.

Three audiences, each with its own levers. I kept the company list cheap on purpose, because cost is the first objection I expect to hear.

20% Twenty-two of these 109 women left the job they returned to. Compare the fully loaded cost of replacing a manager or director with the price of the three things below: a document written while she's out, a backfill, and a ramp. The plan costs a morning of someone's time. Losing her costs a great deal more.

For women and their partners

Write your own return plan. What you want to own, what you'd like handed back gradually, and what you need to be briefed on. Send it in your first days back. The data says nobody is likely to hand you one, but hopefully that will change!

Name the identity question out loud, early. Nearly four in five women felt this conflict, so it is not a sign you chose wrong.

Build the village before you need it. The support that shows up after birth tends to disappear a few weeks in, and losing it affects not only your mood, but your career.

Renegotiate the load at home, on purpose. Hand off whole categories instead of single tasks. Owning bottles means you notice they're dirty without anyone telling you.

Partners: take the full leave, and if there's flexibility, take it after hers. When the two leaves overlap, the imbalance still shows up. It only shows up later.

For companies

Have a re-onboarding plan waiting on day one. You can't contact her during leave, so build it while she's out and hand it over the morning she's back: what she owns, what you aren't asking of her yet, what changed, and who to ask.

Never review a leave period. Leave out the months she was away, and put that in writing.

Backfill, or cut the scope and say so. If three months of work piles up and then you measure how fast she ramps, you've set her up to fail.

Phase the ramp and write it down, so she isn't negotiating it while exhausted.

Train the managers. Manager quality was the biggest variable in every interview, and almost nobody teaches it.

Measure retention at 6 and 12 months after return, and look at separations by leave status. Your employees notice the overall pattern and act on it.

How policy needs to shift

Mandate paid leave, then build what comes after it. The United States is the only developed country without it, and that's the first thing to fix. The UK offers up to 52 weeks, and the same collapse still happens on re-entry.

Make partner leave meaningful, non-transferable and well paid. It's the highest-leverage change available, and it isn't a women's policy. Two weeks of statutory paternity leave sets up an unequal load from day one.

Require a return-to-work protocol alongside the leave entitlement. The law defines how long a person can be away and says nothing about what happens when she comes back. A documented day-one re-onboarding plan would cost employers very little.

Close the eligibility gap. Federal job-protected leave covers only about half of US workers, and protection most people can't access.

Extend postpartum healthcare well past six weeks, with mental health services and pelvic floor therapy as a standard of care. Right now care ends at a single visit, while symptoms show up months later, at weaning and at the return to work. When a woman feels seen and heard at that point, it changes what happens next for her.

IN CLOSING

Changing the composition of the table

Our mothers fought to be let into the room, and that fight worked. It produced a generation of women who are qualified, senior and hard to replace, and who are now walking out of their own careers in the first six months back from leave. Our mothers fought for the seat. Nobody redesigned the room around it.

> *"Our mothers were just trying to get a seat at the table. Now that we are at the table, we have to change the composition of the table."*
>
> STARTUP OPERATOR, SEATTLE

That's what this research is asking for. Women who already carry more than the system was built to hold don't need to be told to be more resilient. They don't need another wellbeing program that treats a design flaw as a personal shortcoming, either. The women in this study named the problem clearly. Two thirds asked for something an employer or a policymaker controls.

The changes that would matter most are unglamorous and cheap: a re-onboarding plan waiting on her first day, someone covering the work while she's gone, a ramp instead of a cliff, a partner with real leave of their own, and care that lasts longer than six weeks. None of it needs a new philosophy of work. It needs someone willing to look honestly at what happens to a woman in her first quarter back, and to plan her return as carefully as we planned her absence.

I've now gone back to work after parental leave three times, and I know exactly which of these would have changed my first return. That's why this paper exists. Every woman in it described some version of the same thing, and not one of them was broken.

You are not broken. The system didn't adjust.

A note on method

Findings come from the first 109 survey responses, collected from August 2026 through LinkedIn and email: 21 statements on a 5-point agreement scale, two open-ended questions and six profile questions. 96 women answered the first open question, 95 answered the second, and 92 answered both. Open responses were coded by theme and could carry more than one, so those percentages add up to more than 100. I also conducted ten semi-structured interviews of 30 to 60 minutes across the United Kingdom, South Africa and seven US locations, in confidence, and quote them by role and location only. The survey is still open and the sample is still growing.

Everything reported here is a pattern in the data, not proof of cause. The sample is self-selected, so the numbers describe this group rather than all mothers. Agreement means 4 or 5 on the 5-point scale. A companion technical appendix has the full statistical detail, including correlation coefficients, significance tests, group comparisons, complete item-level results and the open-response coding frame.